Key Terminology

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Overview

Understanding words like 'neurodiversity', 'neurodiverse', and 'neurodivergent' helps us communicate clearly and respectfully. Since using the wrong term causes confusion, it's helpful to learn the differences.

The term 'neurodiversity' describes the idea that everyone's brain is unique, encompassing all of humanity. You'll want to use it when talking about brain differences as a whole.

A 'neurodivergent' individual has a brain that processes information differently from what's considered typical. Always use this word as an adjective, meaning you should say 'a neurodivergent person' rather than 'a neurodivergent'.

A 'neurotypical' person possesses a brain that functions in a way that society considers standard. This is simply the correct term for anyone who isn't neurodivergent.

You should use 'neurodiverse' only when describing a group of people with a mix of different brain types, like a varied workforce. An entire team can be neurodiverse, but an individual person can't be.

The word 'neurotypes' refers to specific categories of brain function, which include autism, dyslexia, and typical development.

Useful Links

Cleveland Clinic - Neurodiversity

Autism and neurodiversity